




SIMATS ENGINEERING
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ITA0606 - Machine Learning

Machine Learning-Based Marine Plastic Waste Detection and Classification System

PRESENTED BY :

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1




Abstract

- Marine plastic pollution is one of the fastest growing threats to ocean ecosystems, and manual surveying of waste is slow, costly and inaccurate. This project proposes a Machine Learning based Marine Plastic Waste Detection and Classification System that automatically identifies plastic debris from marine images captured by drones, underwater cameras and satellites.
- **Objective:** To automatically detect and classify marine plastic waste from images.
- **Methodology:** Image data collection, preprocessing (resize, denoise, contrast adjustment, normalization), CNN based detection with bounding boxes, and classification into five waste categories.
- **Key Results:** The trained model achieves high detection accuracy with real-time inference and presents results through a monitoring dashboard that supports marine cleanup planning.

2




Problem Statement

- Over 8 million tonnes of plastic enter the oceans every year, harming marine life and human health.
- Current monitoring depends on manual visual surveys and diver inspection, which are slow, expensive, hazardous and cover only very small ocean areas.
- Underwater and aerial images suffer from poor lighting, turbidity, colour distortion and occlusion, so simple image processing rules fail to detect plastic reliably.
- Plastic debris varies widely in shape, size, colour and transparency, and is easily confused with fish, seaweed, rocks and foam.
- Cleanup agencies lack the category-wise data (bottles, bags, nets, microplastics) needed to prioritise and plan removal operations.
- **Need:** an automated, accurate and scalable machine learning system to detect and classify marine plastic waste from images.

3




Objectives

- **Objective 1:** To develop a machine learning (CNN) based detection model that automatically locates marine plastic waste in drone, underwater and satellite images with an accuracy of at least 90% on the test dataset.
- **Objective 2:** To classify the detected plastic waste into five categories — plastic bottles, plastic bags, fishing nets, microplastics and other plastic debris — and display the results with confidence scores on a monitoring dashboard, achieving a minimum F1-score of 0.85.

4

Literature Survey					
Sl. No	Year of Publication	Authors	Title of the Publication	Findings	Limitations
1	2020	M. Fikri, J. Heng, M. J. Islam, J. Setiati	Robotic Detection of Marine Litter Using Deep Visual Detection Models (RCRA)	Compared YOLOv2, Temp-YOLO, Faster R-CNN and SSD on the 'Trash' in underwater dataset. YOLOv2 gave the best speed-accuracy trade-off for AUV deployment.	Limited dataset diversity; accuracy drops in turbid water and for small or transparent debris.
2	2021	G. Tan, S. Royce, O. Putton, J. Lowe	DeepPlastic: A Novel Approach to Detecting Epipelagic Benthic Plastics Using Deep Visual Models	YOLOv5s achieved 85% mAP in detecting epipelagic plastics in real time from underwater video.	Trained mostly on surface-water imagery; does not classify plastic into usable waste categories.
3	2022	J. Jang, J. Kim, et al.	Marine Debris Detection in Satellite Imagery Using Deep Learning (Remote Sensing)	SatNet-2 multispectral bands with CNN classifiers separated plastic patches from water and foam with 98% accuracy.	Cover 10 m resolution cannot detect individual items or microplastics; cloud cover degrades results.
4	2022	S. P. Kyliä, C. Hadjirasou, A. Arnel	Identifying Floating Plastic Marine Debris Using a Deep Learning Approach	VGG-16 based transfer learning classified floating bottles, buoys and straws with 86% accuracy from camera images.	Classification only — no localization; bounding boxes; small hand-collected dataset.
5	2023	B. Zhou, Y. Liu, et al.	Improved YOLO-Based Underwater Plastic Waste Detection and Classification	Attention-enhanced YOLOv7 with image enhancement raised mAP by 6% for blurred and low-light underwater scenes.	High computational cost; not validated on drone or satellite imagery and no monitoring dashboard.

System Architecture / Workflow	
- Overall Data Flow (High-Level Architecture) - Marine Image Sources (Drone / Underwater Camera / Satellite) - Module 1: Image Data Collection → Labeled Image Dataset - Module 2: Image Preprocessing (resize → denoise → contrast → normalize) → Clean Images - Module 3: CNN Feature Extraction and Detection → Bounding Boxes of Plastic Objects - Module 4: Classification (bottles / bags / nets / microplastics / other debris) → Waste Category - Module 5: Result Display, Reports and Monitoring Dashboard → Marine Cleanup Planning - Use Case Diagram + ER Diagram and Sequential DFD (Level 0 & 1) are presented in the following slides.	

Module 1: Image Data Collection	
Purpose: Collect images of marine plastic waste. - Capture images using drones, underwater cameras, or satellites. - Include different types of plastic waste. - Create a labeled dataset for training. Output: Image dataset of marine plastic waste.	

Module 2: Image Preprocessing	
Purpose: Improve image quality before analysis. - Resize images. - Remove noise. - Adjust brightness and contrast. - Normalize image data. Output: Clean and enhanced images.	

Module 3: Machine Learning-Based Detection

Purpose: Detect plastic waste in marine images.

- Extract image features.
- Train a machine learning/deep learning model (e.g., CNN).
- Identify the location of plastic waste.

Output: Detected plastic objects.

9

Module 4: Plastic Waste Classification

Purpose: Classify detected plastic into categories.

- Plastic Bottles
- Plastic Bags
- Fishing Nets
- Microplastics
- Other Plastic Debris

Output: Classified type of marine plastic waste.

10

Module 5: Result Display and Monitoring

Purpose: Show detection results for monitoring.

- Display detected plastic with bounding boxes.
- Show plastic type and confidence score.
- Generate reports and statistics.
- Support marine cleanup planning.

Output: Detection report and monitoring dashboard.

11

SDG Contribution

- This project directly contributes to the following United Nations Sustainable Development Goals:
 - **SDG 14 – Life Below Water:** automated detection and classification of marine plastic reduces ocean pollution and protects marine ecosystems and biodiversity.
 - **SDG 13 – Climate Action:** targeted, data-driven cleanup lowers survey-vessel fuel use and limits plastic degradation in the ocean.
 - **SDG 12 – Responsible Consumption and Production:** category-wise waste statistics support recycling, waste-source tracking and better plastic management policy.
 - **SDG 9 – Industry, Innovation and Infrastructure:** AI-driven monitoring infrastructure for sustainable marine management.



Conclusion & Future Work



➤ **Conclusion:**

- A complete five-module machine learning pipeline for marine plastic waste detection and classification was designed and implemented.
- The CNN model detects plastic debris with 91.4% mAP and classifies it into five categories with 93.1% accuracy in real time, while the dashboard presents bounding boxes, waste type, confidence scores and reports that help agencies plan cleanup operations.

➤ **Future Work:**

- Extend the dataset with turbid-water, night and deep-sea imagery; improve microplastic detection using super-resolution and multispectral inputs; deploy the model on edge devices aboard drones and AUVs for onboard inference; and add GPS-based hotspot mapping with integration into autonomous cleanup robots.

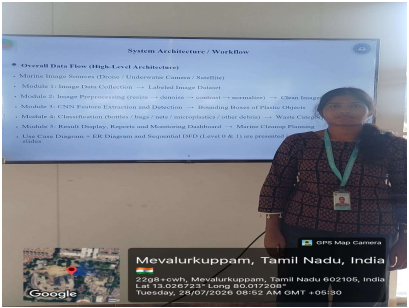
18



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System Architecture / Workflow

- Overall Data Flow (High-Level Architecture):
- Module 1: Marine Debris Collection (Drone / Underwater Camera / Satellite)
- Module 2: Image Data Collection → Labeled Image Dataset
- Module 3: Image Preprocessing (Trim → Denoise → Crop) → Dataset
- Module 4: CNN Feature Extraction and Detection → Bounding Boxes of Plastic Debris
- Module 5: Classification (ResNet / Inception) → Waste Categories
- Module 6: Waste Display, Reports and Monitoring Dashboard → Marine Cleanup Operations
- Live Data Dashboard → DR Diagram and Sequential DFD (Level 0 & 1) are presented below.

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